Why Do We Get Goosebumps From Music?

Roughly two-thirds of people report experiencing chills while listening to music, a phenomenon known as frisson. Participants were split into two groups based on whether they reliably experienced it.

Those who experience frisson have more fibers connecting the auditory cortex to emotional areas, suggesting the two regions talk to each other more efficiently.

Triggers

Chills were most often triggered by unexpected harmonies, sudden changes in volume, or a soloist emerging from an accompaniment. These moments violate the listener’s expectations in a pleasant way.

Personality

The frisson group also scored higher on openness to experience, though the direction of this link remains unclear.